

The Contemporary World - Module 5 Reviewer

Contemporary Global Governance

Overview

No world government exists, yet global problems require coordination. This module studies how states, institutions, and citizens manage shared problems.

Learning Outcomes

- Define global governance and its main actors.
- Explain the structure and functions of the United Nations.
- Compare regional organizations such as the EU and ASEAN.
- Evaluate the role of global civil society and current challenges.

Global Governance Defined

Global governance is the collective management of transnational problems through institutions, rules, and cooperation, without a single world government. Its actors include states, international organizations, corporations, and NGOs.

- Governance without government
- Multiple actors and levels
- Examples: climate, trade, health

The United Nations

Founded in 1945, the UN maintains peace and security, promotes human rights, and coordinates development. Its main organs include the General Assembly, the Security Council (with five permanent members holding veto power), and the Secretariat.

- General Assembly: all members, one vote each
- Security Council: five permanent members with veto
- Specialized agencies: WHO, UNESCO, UNICEF

Regional Organizations

Regional bodies link neighboring states. The European Union has deep economic and political integration, including a shared currency for many members. ASEAN, founded in 1967, emphasizes consensus and non-interference, with the Philippines as a founding member.

- EU: deep integration
- ASEAN: consensus and non-interference
- Other examples: African Union, Mercosur

Global Civil Society

NGOs, advocacy networks, and social movements push governments and firms to act on human rights, environment, and labor concerns. Campaigns such as the ban on landmines show how citizen networks can change international rules.

- NGOs and transnational advocacy
- Social movements
- Legitimacy and accountability questions

Governance Challenges Today

Climate change, pandemics, cyber threats, and migration cross every border. Institutions struggle with slow decision-making, unequal power, and lack of enforcement, prompting calls for reform.

- Climate and the Paris Agreement
- Pandemic response lessons
- Reform of the Security Council

Review Questions

1. Explain: Global Governance Defined.
2. Explain: The United Nations.
3. Explain: Regional Organizations.
4. Explain: Global Civil Society.
5. Explain: Governance Challenges Today.